third-class passengers. A report listed out the following complaints of third-class passengers in 1903:

- Overcrowding of carriages and insufficiency of trains
- Use of cattle trucks and goods wagons for pilgrims
- Absence of latrines in the coaches and their extremely unsuitable character
- Absence of arrangements for meals and insufficient drinking water
- Absence of waiting halls and their extremely uncomfortable nature when available
- Inadequate booking facilities
- Harassment at checking and examination of tickets
- Bribery and exactions at stations, platforms and in the train
- Want of courtesy and sympathetic treatment of passengers by railway staff

A century later, many of these complaints still ring true. Thankfully, cattle trucks are no longer used for passengers but the resentment still remains. An innocuous comment about ‘cattle class’ by Shashi Tharoor (then a minister) in 2009 would lead to an uproar.

HIGH NOON OF EMPIRE

The period between the Revolt of 1857 and the First World War was the high noon of the British Empire. Nowhere was this more evident than in Calcutta (now Kolkata), the empire’s eastern capital. Extravagant buildings embodying Victorian confidence were constructed by the government, banks, companies and wealthy individuals. A surprisingly large number of them have survived into the twenty-first century, hidden behind billboards and other debris of later times. One of the positive consequences of its economic decline in the second half of the twentieth century is that Kolkata is home to the finest collection of nineteenth-century buildings that have survived anywhere in the world. The best way to see it is to wander around the financial district around Lal Dighi on a Sunday morning when the chaotic traffic and the crowds will not distract from the beauty of the old streetscape.

The area used to be called Dalhousie Square but has since been renamed after three Indian revolutionaries Binoy, Badal and Dinesh. Be sure to see the High Court, the Writers’ Building, the Chartered Bank Building, the